

India



A vast subcontinent that has been home to some of the world's oldest civilizations.

2600 BCE Indus Valley civilization flourishes.

1500 BCE Aryan invaders destroy the Indus civilization. The Vedic age develops the Brahmanic caste system of Hinduism.

320–185 BCE The Mauryan Empire unifies most of India and establishes Buddhism as the state religion.

320 CE Foundation of the Gupta dynasty and the beginning of the "Classical Age."

455 CE The arrival of the Huns and the overthrow of the Guptas.

606–47 Harsha Vardhana unites northern India in the Harsha Empire. Kannauj is its capital. After the fall of the Harsha Empire, Kannauj becomes capital of the Pratihara Empire.

711 Muslim armies conquer Sind.

750–1150 Buddhism flourishes in eastern India.

800s Expansion of the Chola Empire in southern India. By the 11th century, it includes the Maldives, parts of Burma, Malaya, and Sumatra.

800–1200 Period of Rajput kingdoms in Rajputana (present-day Rajasthan), northwest India.

1000–25 Mahmud of Ghazni invades from Afghanistan into northern India.

1018 City of Kannauj falls to Turkish invaders.

1192 Rajput king Prithviraj III is defeated by Muslim forces. This marks the end of the Rajput period.

1192–1398 The Muslim Delhi Sultanate is established in the Indo-Gangetic plain of northern India.

1200s Chola Empire begins to shrink as neighboring kingdoms take its land.

Bronze Chola god

This 11th-century Chola bronze depicts the Hindu god Rama. Hinduism was the religion of the Chola Empire; its kings were thought to be descendants of the god Shiva. Other religions were tolerated.



1279 Rajendra III, the last Chola king, dies. The Chola Empire is overthrown by rival kingdoms.

c.1300 Muslim sultans of Delhi attack southern India, extending their kingdom.

1336 Hindu kingdom of Vijayanagar is founded in southern India. It halts Muslim expansion in the south.

1398 Delhi is sacked by the Mongol army of Timur (Tamerlane).

1526 The establishment of the Mughal Empire, which reaches its peak during the reign of Emperor Akbar (1556–1605).

1632 Construction of the Taj Mahal, a mausoleum commissioned by Emperor Shah Jahan for his favorite wife, Mumtaz Mahal, is begun at Agra.

1659 Shivaji Bhonsle leads a small, ill-equipped Maratha army to defeat a much greater Adilshahi force at the Battle of Pratapggarh.

1674 Maratha Empire is established by Shivaji Bhonsle in central and northern India. It dominates the region until 1818.

1707 The death of Emperor Aurangzeb marks the onset of Mughal decline.

1757 British military victory in Bengal by the East India Company's private army, led by Robert Clive, heralds the consolidation of British power in India.

1777 The first Anglo-Maratha war begins between the East India Company and the Maratha Empire. Further wars start in 1803 and 1817.

1857 Sepoy rebellion spreads across India and is suppressed the following year.

1858 Formal dissolution of Mughal Empire and the assumption of direct control by the British government.

1877 Queen Victoria is proclaimed empress of India.

1885 The Indian National Congress is formed as a forum for the nationalist movement.

1919 Act of parliament introduces "responsible government."

1920–22 Mahatma Gandhi's first civil disobedience campaign.

1935 Government of India Act grants autonomy to provinces.

1936 First elections under new constitution.

1942–43 "Quit India" movement launched by the Indian National Congress.

DECISIVE MOMENT

THE SEPOY REBELLION, 1857–58

The Sepoy Rebellion was a widespread revolt against British rule that began among Indian soldiers in the East India Company. It was sparked by the introduction of the Enfield rifle, for which troops had to bite the ends off cartridges that were allegedly greased with pig and cow lard, contact with which was regarded as an insult to Muslims and Hindus alike. More generally, however, the rebellion stemmed from discontent with insensitive British attempts to Westernize India. Troops in Meerut who refused the

rifles in April 1857 were severely punished. In response their comrades shot their British officers and marched on Delhi, where the local Indian garrison joined a spreading revolt that was not suppressed until nearly a year later. After the rebellion, which many in India now consider to have been a first war of independence, the British stepped back from imposing measures and began a process of consultation with Indians over policy. Seen here are rebels tied to cannons as punishment.



1947 End of British rule and partition into a Hindu-majority India and a Muslim-dominated Pakistan. Jawaharlal Nehru becomes first prime minister of independent India.

1948 Assassination of Mahatma Gandhi by a Hindu extremist. War with Pakistan over Kashmir.

1950 India becomes a republic.

1951–52 First general election is won by Congress Party under Nehru.

1957 Congress Party is reelected. First elected communist state government is installed in Kerala.

1960 Bombay is divided into the states of Gujarat and Maharashtra.

1962 Congress Party reelected. India loses war with China over Aksai Chin.

1964 Nehru dies. Lal Bahadur Shastri becomes prime minister.

1965 Second war with Pakistan over Kashmir.

1966 Prime minister Lal Bahadur Shastri dies; Indira Gandhi (daughter of Jawaharlal Nehru) is chosen as a compromise candidate to replace him.

1969 Congress Party splits into two factions. The larger faction is led by Indira Gandhi.

1971 Indira Gandhi's Congress (R) Party wins elections. Third war with Pakistan, over the creation of Bangladesh. Twenty-year friendship treaty signed with USSR.

1972 Simla Agreement signed with Pakistan, laying down principles for peace.

1974 Explosion of first nuclear device in underground test.

1975 Indira Gandhi declares a state of emergency after being found guilty of electoral malpractice.

1975–77 Program of compulsory birth control introduced. Nearly 1,000 political opponents are jailed.

1977 Congress Party loses general election. People's Party (JD) takes power.

1978 New political splinter group, Congress (Indira)—C(I)—Party is established and led by Indira Gandhi.

1980 Congress (I) wins general election.

1984 Indian troops storm Golden Temple in Amritsar to capture militants seeking Sikh self rule. Indira Gandhi assassinated by her Sikh bodyguards; her son Rajiv becomes prime minister and C(I) leader. Gas explosion at US-owned Union Carbide plant in Bhopal kills 2,000.

1987 Indian peacekeeping force is deployed in Sri Lanka to combat Tamil Tigers. It loses 1,200 men.